

International Politics

Sample Syllabus

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Upper-division undergraduate | 3 credits | 15-week semester

About this document. This is a sample syllabus prepared for teaching portfolio purposes. It presents my own course design: the sequencing, the assessment architecture, the assignment prompts, and the reading selection. Calendar dates, meeting times, course numbers, learning-management-system references, and institution-specific administrative policies have been removed, and weeks are numbered rather than dated so that the design can be read independently of any particular academic calendar. A course actually offered would carry the host institution's required policy statements.

Course Description

International Politics investigates the interactions between states and other actors in world affairs: political, military, diplomatic, and economic. The course provides a structured walkthrough of the field's major questions, with an emphasis on the capacity to understand, analyze, and apply theoretical frameworks to the world as it currently is.

The course examines how standard international relations theories operate within an anarchic system, and it asks students to weigh strategic and economic models against considerations of human dignity and the common good. We explore theories of war and peace, international political economy, development, and the transnational challenges that cut across state boundaries. The analytical and writing demands of the course are designed to build tools that transfer directly to careers in diplomacy, international business, public service, education, and advocacy.

Design Note: What This Course Is For

Every course I teach serves two objectives, and the assessment structure below is built to deliver them rather than to sample them.

One. Critical thinking, by crossing theory with real cases. A theory that has never been tested against a case that strains it has not been learned. Each week pairs a theoretical framework with a puzzle that the framework handles imperfectly, and the weekly Analytical Brief requires students to take a position on that friction rather than summarize the reading. Students are expected to name the trade-off at stake, argue a position, and state the strongest version of the view they reject before attacking it.

Two. Policy orientation. I do not teach international politics as history. The Collective Policy Task Force places students inside an unfolding crisis with incomplete information, and the Final Research Paper requires them to analyze a live regional or global issue and defend a recommendation. The point of the theory is that it should help someone decide something.

These two objectives explain why the course is weighted toward cumulative writing and away from

examinations. Students produce a body of argument over fifteen weeks, receive feedback on it while it is still revisable, and finish with work they can show someone outside the classroom.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- 1. Define and correctly use the concepts and terminology central to the study of contemporary international politics and diplomacy.
- 2. Apply a body of factual knowledge to explain the causes and effects of international conflict and cooperation among nation-states.
- 3. Evaluate the ethical implications of state behavior and of global institutions, weighing strategic and economic models against considerations of human dignity and the common good.
- 4. Analyze competing explanations for patterns of conflict and cooperation, including how illicit and informal economic activity shapes state behavior and violence.
- 5. Produce clear, concise, and analytically rigorous policy writing, both individually and collaboratively.

Required Text

Jeffrey A. Frieden, David A. Lake, and Kenneth A. Schultz. *World Politics: Interests, Interactions, and Institutions*, 6th Edition. New York: W. W. Norton. [Abbreviated “FLS” below]

Additional required articles are drawn from the peer-reviewed literature and are listed by week in the course outline. Students access them through the library’s subscriptions rather than through course-provided copies.

Assessment

Component	Weight
Seminar Participation	15%
Analytical Briefs (6 required)	25%
Individual Theory-to-Practice Mid-Term Essay	20%
Collective Policy Task Force	10%
Final Research Paper	20%
Draft Presentation and Peer-Review Session	10%
Total	100%

Formatting. All major written assignments are double-spaced and follow APA style. Stated lengths are strict maximum word limits. Bibliographies and references are excluded from the word limit. Graphs, charts, and tables are placed in appendices and do not count toward the body word limit.

Seminar Participation (15%)

Active participation is essential. Students arrive having completed the assigned readings, prepared to dissect theories, evaluate cases, and contribute to collective problem-solving. Attendance accounts for 5% of the final grade; the quality of contribution to discussion accounts for the remaining 10%.

Analytical Briefs (25%)

Students submit **six** analytical briefs of 250 to 300 words over the semester. Up to eight may be submitted, in which case the two lowest scores are dropped. Each brief responds to the week's theoretical puzzle, listed with that week in the course outline.

Critical thinking expectation. A brief that summarizes the reading receives a failing grade for that brief. Students are expected to interrogate the assumptions underlying the week's argument, assess the strength of its empirical evidence, and consider alternative explanations. A strong brief dissects a complex phenomenon, identifies a bias or gap in the standard narrative, and defends a conclusion that the writer could be argued out of but has not been.

Individual Theory-to-Practice Mid-Term Essay (20%)

A single comprehensive essay of no more than 1,300 words serves as the midterm assessment. The prompt pairs a specific global topic with an analytical question and is distributed one week before the due date. The essay is evaluated on the accuracy of its theoretical application, the quality of its evidence, and the honesty with which it handles the strongest objection to its own argument.

Collective Policy Task Force (10%)

Students work in groups in a single extended class session, structured to mimic professional interdisciplinary collaboration. Each group is assigned an unfolding global crisis and participates in a live simulation, applying course theory to propose a strategic policy response under time pressure and with incomplete information. Groups are assessed on the coherence of their reasoning and their handling of the trade-offs their recommendation creates, not on reaching a predetermined answer.

Final Research Paper (20%)

Students work in **pairs** to produce a research paper of 2,000 to 2,250 words addressing the core challenges facing a specific global sub-region or a specific global issue. Selected issues must be analyzed through a strict international relations perspective.

Each student ranks up to three preferred topics from the lists below, and pairs are formed to match shared interests where possible.

Regions. Sub-Saharan Africa; East Asia and the Pacific; Western Europe; Eastern Europe; the Middle East and North Africa; South and Central Asia; Central America and the Caribbean; South America. A student selecting a region takes a specific issue examined during the semester and applies it strictly to that geographic area.

Global issues. Artificial intelligence; U.S.–China competition; illicit economies (narcotics, human trafficking, cybercrime); poverty and development; trade and supply chains; active interstate wars; and contemporary Latin American socialism.

Draft Presentation and Peer-Review Session (10%)

Each pair delivers a ten-minute presentation of their draft, covering the question, the context, the main analytical concern, initial findings, and policy implications, followed by five minutes of questions.

In a structured peer-review workshop, each pair brings physical copies of a rough draft of at least 1,000 words and conducts exactly two reviews of other pairs' drafts, ensuring every paper receives at least two evaluations. This component is graded substantially on the depth, precision, and constructive quality of the feedback a student gives to classmates, not only on the quality of their own presentation. Students are being assessed on their capacity to improve someone else's argument.

Course Policies

Use of Generative AI

AI tools may be used as research and search instruments: to explore a topic, identify relevant concepts, locate potential sources, or deepen understanding of unfamiliar material, provided that students independently verify the information and consult the original sources.

AI tools may not be used to produce, compose, rewrite, or paraphrase text for submission; to answer questions assigned as coursework; to generate analyses or arguments; or to complete any portion of an assignment on a student's behalf. Students independently produce the written work they submit. The use of AI does not reduce a student's responsibility for the accuracy, originality, and proper attribution of their work.

Late Work

Work submitted without an acceptable excuse is penalized one full letter grade per day late, including non-business days. Work more than three days late without an approved excuse receives no credit. Where a documented circumstance prevents timely submission, students contact me within two business days of the deadline, preferably in advance, to arrange an extension or an alternative.

Communication

Announcements are posted weekly. Private administrative concerns go to institutional email; general course questions go to an open discussion board, so that classmates benefit from shared answers. Office hours are held weekly with both drop-in windows and scheduled individual appointments.

Course Outline

Readings are completed before the first meeting of the week. Chapters from the FLS text are required; the additional articles listed each week provide foundational depth and analytical extensions. The analytical brief question listed with each week guides that week's submission.

MODULE I: Foundations of World Politics

This module establishes the historical context and theoretical framework for the course. Students examine the evolution of the international system and learn to analyze global events through the core concepts of actors' interests, strategic interactions, and the constraining role of institutions.

Week 1: Introduction: Rival Theories of World Politics

Readings:

- FLS, Introduction.
- Snyder, Jack. 2004. "One World, Rival Theories." *Foreign Policy* 145: 52–62.

No brief this week.

Week 2: What Shaped Our World? A Historical Introduction

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 1.
- Gaddis, John Lewis. 1992. "International Relations Theory and the End of the Cold War." *International Security* 17(3): 5–58.

Analytical Brief: What shaped our world? Identify the single structural change you find most consequential and defend that choice against the strongest rival account.

Week 3: Interests, Interactions, and Institutions

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 2.
- Baldwin, David A. 1997. "The Concept of Security." *Review of International Studies* 23(1): 5–26.
- Morrow, James. 1999. "The Strategic Setting of Choices: Signaling, Commitment, and Negotiation in International Politics." In David Lake and Robert Powell, eds., *Strategic Choice and International Relations*. Princeton University Press, 77–114.

Analytical Brief: What do actors want from politics? Why can't actors always get what they want? Do rules matter in world politics?

MODULE II: War, Peace, and Security

This module investigates the causes and dynamics of armed conflict. It examines rationalist explanations for why states go to war, how domestic politics and international institutions influence decisions to fight, and the specific logic driving violence by nonstate actors in civil wars and terrorism.

Week 4: Why Are There Wars?

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 3.
- Fearon, James. 1995. "Rationalist Explanations for War." *International Organization* 49(3): 379–414.
- Yarhi-Milo, Keren. 2013. "In the Eye of the Beholder: How Leaders Assess Intentions in International Politics." *International Security* 38(1): 7–51.

Analytical Brief: What is the purpose of war? What do states actually fight over, and does the rationalist account survive contact with the case you know best?

Week 5: Domestic Politics and War

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 4.
- Tomz, Michael. 2007. "Domestic Audience Costs in International Relations: An Experimental Approach." *International Organization* 61: 821–840.

Analytical Brief: Why doesn't politics stop at the water's edge? Do politicians spark wars abroad in order to hold power at home? Why don't democracies fight one another?

Week 6: International Institutions and War

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 5.
- Allen, Susan Hannah, and Amy T. Yuen. 2014. "The Politics of Peacekeeping: UN Security Council Oversight Across Peacekeeping Missions." *International Studies Quarterly* 58(3): 621–632.

Analytical Brief: Why promise to fight someone else's war? When can the UN keep the peace?

Week 7: Violence by Nonstate Actors: Civil War and Terrorism

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 6.

- Kalyvas, Stathis N. 2006. *The Logic of Violence in Civil War*. Cambridge University Press, Chapter 1.
- Kydd, Andrew H., and Barbara F. Walter. 2006. "The Strategies of Terrorism." *International Security* 31(1): 49–80.

Analytical Brief: Why does war occur within states? Why kill civilians?

Milestone: Mid-term essay prompt distributed.

MODULE III: International Political Economy and Development

Shifting from security to economics, this module analyzes the cross-border flow of goods, money, and people. Students explore the political economy of international trade and finance, the mechanics of monetary relations, and the systemic factors that drive the wealth and poverty of nations.

Week 8: Cross-Border Flows of Goods and Services

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 7.
- Rodrik, Dani. 2018. "Populism and the Economics of Globalization." *Journal of International Business Policy* 1(1–2): 12–33.

Milestone: Mid-term essay due.

Week 9: Cross-Border Flows of Money and People

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 8.
- Farrell, Henry, and Abraham L. Newman. 2019. "Weaponized Interdependence: How Global Economic Networks Shape State Coercion." *International Security* 44(1): 42–79.
- Reinhart, Carmen M., and Kenneth S. Rogoff. 2011. "From Financial Crash to Debt Crisis." *American Economic Review* 101(5): 1676–1706.

Milestone: Research pairs and topics confirmed.

Week 10: International Monetary Relations

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 9.
- Lang, Valentin. 2021. “The Economics of the Democratic Deficit: The Effect of IMF Programs on Inequality.” *Journal of Political Economy* 129(3): 865–915.
- Heimberger, Philipp, et al. 2024. “Debt Sustainability Analysis in Reformed EU Fiscal Rules.” *Intereconomics* 59(5): 276–283.

Analytical Brief: What are exchange rates, and why do they matter? How are currency values determined, and who is disadvantaged by the answer?

Week 11: Development: The Causes of the Wealth and Poverty of Nations

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 10.
- Banerjee, Abhijit, and Esther Duflo. 2011. *Poor Economics*. New York: PublicAffairs, Chapters 1 and 9.
- Nunn, Nathan, and Nancy Qian. 2014. “US Food Aid and Civil Conflict.” *American Economic Review* 104(6): 1630–1666.
- Bueno de Mesquita, Bruce, and Alastair Smith. 2009. “A Political Economy of Aid.” *International Organization* 63(2): 309–340.

Milestone: Collective Policy Task Force simulation, in class.

MODULE IV: Transnational Politics and the Future of Global Order

The final module addresses contemporary global challenges that transcend traditional state boundaries. Students evaluate the effectiveness of international law and norms, human security interventions, and environmental cooperation, culminating in an assessment of the challenges facing the modern liberal international order.

Week 12: International Law, Norms, and Order

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 11.
- Kelley, Judith G., and Beth A. Simmons. 2015. “Politics by Number: Indicators as Social Pressure in International Relations.” *American Journal of Political Science* 59(1): 55–70.

- Simmons, Beth A. 1998. "Compliance with International Agreements." *Annual Review of Political Science* 1(1): 75–93.

Analytical Brief: What is international law, and what are international norms, if there is no authority to enforce them?

Week 13: International Institutions and Human Security

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 12.
- Finnemore, Martha. 2003. *The Purpose of Intervention: Changing Beliefs about the Use of Force*. Cornell University Press, Chapter 3.

Milestone: Draft peer-review session, part I. Rough drafts due in class.

Week 14: The Global Environment and Collective Action

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 13.
- Hardin, Garrett. 1968. "The Tragedy of the Commons." *Science* 162(3859): 1243–1248.
- Ostrom, Elinor. 1990. *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action*. Cambridge University Press, Chapter 1.

Milestone: Draft peer-review session, part II. Presentations begin.

Week 15: Challenges to the Global Order

Readings:

- FLS, Chapter 14.
- Huntington, Samuel P. 1993. "The Clash of Civilizations?" *Foreign Affairs* 72(3): 22–49.
- Mearsheimer, John J. 2019. "Bound to Fail: The Rise and Fall of the Liberal International Order." *International Security* 43(4): 7–50.

Milestone: Remaining student briefings and closing discussion.

Final Research Papers due during the examination period.